

To the professor of international law

Draft for Mitch's hand — sending is the door. Salutation left open until the university is chosen.

Dear Professor —

I want to tell you about a machine in a flight case, and about a small law it carries that your students could hold to a standard most statutes never meet: the law checks itself for coherence, and it can prove what it makes impossible.

Let me start with the story, because the course does. In the seminar room there is a shared computer — no cloud behind it, nothing it hears ever leaves the room. The students call it the mage, because a good name matters and they chose it together. Douglas Adams gave us the babel fish: drop it in your ear and every tongue becomes yours. This course runs the babel fish in reverse. Each week, students take one understanding and are asked to carry it across three tongues — a science-fiction story that casts it forward, a poem that compresses it until a person can say it aloud, and a formal paper that makes it checkable. A blind examiner — one that has never seen the answer key — is handed *one* of the three tongues, drawn by a hash nobody can influence, and must recover from that text alone every claim it says it carries. A translation that is beautiful but no longer carries the mechanism is caught. That is the whole pedagogy: **understanding is only counted when it survives translation.** I suspect you recognise the shape — it is what treaty drafting has always demanded of a text that must live in six languages at once.

Here is the part I am writing to you specifically about. The workshop's own legal layer — the consent agreement each student signs, the duties of the weekly steward, even the examination procedure itself — is written in **Lexon**, a controlled natural language: prose a lawyer reads without training that a machine parses without mercy.

Three registers of the same agreement exist side by side (plain language, legal, machine-readable — the structure of **IEEE 7012-2025**, the "MyTerms" standard, which inverts notice-and-consent so that *the individual proposes the terms* and the institution accepts, counters once, or declines). The Lexon text is the fourth register, and it is two of them at once. Every clause compiles through a grammar gate; every structural claim the law makes is verified against the clause graph — including, and this is the part I would most like to put in front of your students, **absence claims**: the checker proves that *no clause routes a student's expression to the workshop-holder*. Extraction is not forbidden. It is structurally impossible, and a mutated twin of the contract — one that quietly adds the route — is generated and caught, mechanically, every time the suite runs. A prohibition you can disobey; an absence you would have to *amend into existence*, in public, in a diff.

There is a jurisprudential thesis under this that I hold seriously and would enjoy defending in your seminar. The workshop's founding proverb, arrived at by way of Gödel: *any agreement complete enough to need no one outside it has either stopped listening or begun to lie*. So everything here is built incomplete on purpose — the consent ledger keeps a visible strike-through when a student withdraws (the right to leave is part of the record, not an embarrassment to it), the trust artefacts are witnessed by communities standing outside the agreements they witness, and the one gate no machine may open — publication, the outward act — belongs to a person, always. Law students tend to meet "code is law" as a slogan to attack. I would rather they meet it as a drafting exercise with a compiler that tells them when their clauses contradict themselves, and a checker that asks the better question: *what does your contract make impossible?*

What the university receives is a public good in the strict sense. The whole instrument — harness, mage, law lane, bound-book pipeline — arrives in the flight case and stays: no subscription, no API, no data leaving the building. The students walk away with a book of their poems, a collection of their papers, and something I have not seen a course give before: **verifiable provenance as the first trainers of an institution's own AI** — a signed, hash-chained steward log in which every student's name appears, replayable offline by anyone, forever. Their consent architecture is not

a form they signed at intake; it is the thing they studied, drafted in, and can walk a regulator through afterwards.

None of this is a proposal in the speculative sense. It is built. The gates are green; the examiner ran its first live round on a local model this week; the laws compile — twenty-six checks, including the twins. What I am asking for is a room, eight to fourteen masters students, and a colleague on the law side willing to co-hold the question this course keeps open: what does agreement mean, when the text can finally check itself — and still, on purpose, cannot certify itself?

I would be glad to bring the flight case to you and run the first hour: it begins, as it should, with a story about a name that died.

With respect and anticipation,

Mitchell Travers mitchell@soulbis.com · the agentprivacy work:
github.com/mitchuski/agentprivacy-harness